

Loaded Headline Laboratory Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and Language • 25-35 min

Category	Knowledge and Language	Time	25-35 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	loaded-headline-laboratory

Big idea: Wording frames interpretation.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Headline cards using verbs such as 'admits', 'claims', 'reveals', and 'warns'. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Loaded Headline Laboratory Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A trust rating before and after students see the same evidence. Annotate the wording. Circle the words that change tone, emotion, implication, or trust.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Wording frames interpretation.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Loaded Headline Laboratory Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	Can language be neutral?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines.
- Headline cards using verbs such as 'admits', 'claims', 'reveals', and 'warns'.
- A trust rating before and after students see the same evidence.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and Language.

Activity Steps

1. Groups rewrite the event as a school announcement, tabloid headline, human rights report, police report, student activist post and parent message.
2. The class identifies loaded words, omitted details and implied blame.
3. Students reconstruct the most neutral version possible.
4. Discuss whether complete neutrality is possible.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: Can language be neutral?
- How does word choice affect what we think we know?
- Is objective description possible?

Knowledge Questions

- Can language be neutral?
- How does word choice affect what we think we know?
- Is objective description possible?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with a neutral claim rewritten as alarming, heroic, bureaucratic, and sceptical headlines. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...